

AUDIBLE KI SUNO

Making a rich audiobook experience more accessible

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On the eve of the launch of their newest service, Audible Suno, in India, we sit down with Don Katz, Founder and CEO, and Shailesh Sawlani, VP, Country GM Audible India, to understand their motivation for venturing out into the podcast space. Audible Suno is a free service with exclusive content voiced by noted storytellers such as Amitabh Bachchan, Rajeev Masand, Vir Das, Neelesh Mishra, Neena Gupta, Mouni Roy and others.

d A lot of companies are focusing their attention on podcasts and even in India, specifically. Everyone's been giving different reasons for doing so and I wanted your perspective as to why you're launching Audible Suno?

DON KATZ

So Audible Suno is a first, all original launch. We're not leveraging the audio book franchise that we built, which is huge from all over the world. We're trying to leverage the depth of creativity and the professional creative community in India - which is in many ways deeper than anywhere else - towards Audible Suno. When we were planning Suno, all kinds of people came out of the woodwork with ideas for the future of the listening aesthetic, that's Audible. There's the fact that we have a great team here which is very connected to the professional community and that helped a lot.

The idea was, let's do something that nobody else has done, with no advertising, no charge and just push it out. Then



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make it like a test tube of learning that consists of everything from the creative output to the consumer feedback, which we can then use in all of our services around the world. India seemed to be the right place to do that, so that's what we focused on here.

The podcast concept in the states is 750,000 people talking, often into their microphones. It's not necessarily an organised thing and the revenue is mostly from advertising. It's not gigantic, but, it's a very interesting way to see different people doing things that are important to them as speakers, and finding listeners in the world that care. As a company that kind of created a listening revolution, created the category and turned it into a really successful

business without naming it "podcast", most people around the world relate podcasts to the audible experience, be it long form, short form or whatever. Now, we decided to draw in some of the best voices and the best creativity for this. The exciting thing is that it's not just the writers and the actors, which is usually our main group of creators that we go to, but it's also the amazing number of directors, producers, soundscape designers and sound innovators are all coming onboard to help us define Suno in India. It's super exciting for me because the vision of the company wasn't just audiobooks, it was audiobooks as performed by sophisticated and nuanced acting. It was also having Robin Williams doing original programming